

AYESHA AHMED

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RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics, Behavioral & Experimental Economics, Credit Markets & Risk Management

EDUCATION

Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics, University of California, Davis	2021–expected 2027
<i>Dissertation: Repayment and Non-Price Credit Rationing in Microfinance</i>	
M.S.S. in Economics (top 2% of graduating class), University of Dhaka	2019
B.S.S. in Economics (top 1% of graduating class), University of Dhaka	2015–2018

DISSERTATION COMMITTEE

Prof. Michael R. Carter (Chair)	Prof. Stephen R. Boucher	Prof. Anujit Chakraborty
Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics	Department of Agricultural and Resource Economics	Department of Economics
University of California, Davis	University of California, Davis	University of California, Davis
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WORKING PAPERS

Ahmed, A. 2026. “Audience Effect in Microfinance: Does Social Observability of Default Increase Repayment?” (Job Market Paper)

Does making default observable to peers increase repayment in individual liability microfinance? I study this question in a framed lab-in-the-field experiment with 919 agricultural borrowers across 100 borrowing groups in Bangladesh, varying whether default is observable to peers for a hypothetical microfinance loan. The within-subject design identifies the audience effect on repayment. I find that an audience raises repayment by 3.3 to 5.3 percent relative to repayment without an audience, with no detectable variation across income states. The conceptual framework interprets repayment without an audience as reflecting intrinsic motivation and the additional repayment induced by an audience as reflecting reputational motivation. A reduction in field default of the same magnitude would raise lender profit by 34 to 55 percent of the zero-default margin.

Mahzab, M., **Ahmed, A.**, Brooks, N., Mahajan, A., Luby, S., Biswas, D., Ahmed, R. and Ahmed, S. 2026. “When Corruption is the Norm: Can Signaling Environmental Compliance Reduce Bribery?”

This paper studies whether credible signaling of regulatory compliance can reduce illicit payments in the brick kiln industry in Bangladesh. We exploit variation in banner display induced by randomized assignment to a broader environment friendly technology intervention and use the intervention as an instrument to identify the effect of compliance signaling. The banner signals both higher profitability and environmental compliance and the conceptual framework shows that its net effect on rent extraction depends on officials’ preferences over their relative values. Empirically, the latter effect dominates and each additional week of banner display lowers bribe payments by 18.6 percent and compliance costs by 5.4 percent.

RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

“Minimum Wages and Consumer Demand: Evidence from U.S. Fast-Food Chains” with Modhurima Dey Amin, Syed Badruddoza

This study examines how minimum wage regulation affects consumer spending and store revenue in the U.S. fast-food industry. Using a triple differences (DDD) design, we exploit variation across states, over time, and between chains covered and not covered by California’s fast-food minimum wage law (AB 1228). The analysis uses a high frequency panel of 680,000 store-level sales and customer traffic, with data processing and analysis implemented in Python.

“Repayment Motivations and Financial Behaviors in Microfinance: Do Experimental Measures Predict Field Decisions?”

This study develops individual-specific measures of intrinsic and reputational motivations for repayment from repeated choices in a framed lab-in-the-field experiment with microfinance borrowers. A structural model is used to recover borrower-specific behavioral parameters from censored repayment choices, using random-effects Tobit and two-limit Tobit specifications while accounting for measurement error in the recovered parameters. The resulting measures are then used to examine whether experimentally elicited repayment motivations predict subsequent field outcomes, including insurance uptake and non-price credit rationing.

“Indexed Financial Tools and Risk Rationing in Microfinance” with Michael Carter

This study examines whether indexed financial tools reduce risk rationing among smallholder microfinance borrowers in Bangladesh. Through a large-scale randomized experiment with 6,683 farmers, we compare standalone agricultural index insurance with insurance bundled with savings and a contingent line of credit, and estimate their effects on different forms of non-price credit rationing. We also examine whether risk rationing is more prevalent among borrowers who are more responsive to reputational incentives, testing whether social collateral discourages borrowing under risk.

“Measuring Non-Price Credit Rationing in Microfinance”

This study measures the prevalence and composition of non-price credit rationing among microfinance borrowers in Bangladesh. We adapt the Direct Elicitation Method to the microfinance setting to distinguish borrowers who are quantity rationed, price rationed, or risk rationed. The resulting measures provide a framework for studying how borrower characteristics and exposure to risk shape credit demand and access.

GRANTS, FELLOWSHIPS, AND AWARDS

2026	Jastro & Shields Graduate Research Award, UC Davis (\$3,000)
2024, 2026	ARE Summer Research Fellowship, UC Davis (total \$4,500)
2025	ARE Graduate Travel Award, UC Davis (\$1,250)
2024	Subgrant , Resilience+ Innovation Facility, UC Davis (\$30,740), for an experimental extension to the RCT on <i>Bundling Indexed Financial Tools for Smallholder Producers</i>
2021	First-Year Summer Fellowship, UC Davis (\$5,000)
2019	Shamsun Nahar Mahmud Foundation Merit Award, University of Dhaka
2015–2017	Governor’s Scholarship, University of Dhaka

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

2026	Northeastern Universities Development Consortium (NEUDC); AAEA Annual Meeting, MO; Symposium in Honor of Michael Carter; Pacific Conference for Development Economics (PacDev) (presented by coauthor)
2025	AAEA & WAEA Joint Annual Meeting, CO (Poster); 14th Annual Bay Area Behavioral Economics and Experimental Workshop
2023	Fourth SANEM–World Bank North America Discussion Forum, Washington, DC
2019	15th South Asian Economics Students’ Meet, World Bank, Colombo (Best Paper); 4th SANEM Annual Economists’ Conference, Dhaka
2018	14th South Asian Economics Students’ Meet, World Bank, Bangladesh; 1st Bangladesh Economics Summit, University of Dhaka (Best Paper); Speakonomics at EconFest, North South University (Best Paper)

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

2022–Present Graduate Student Researcher

University of California, Davis (PI: Prof. Michael Carter)

- Randomized controlled trial on indexed financial tools among smallholder farmers (ongoing): contributing to experimental design, leading field implementation including enumerator training, coordinating with research partners, and producing interim analyses to refine research instruments and field protocols.
- Lab-in-the-field experiment on the audience effect in microfinance: conceptualized and designed the study, developed the measurement strategy, led field implementation, and conducted the empirical analysis.

- Direct elicitation of non-price credit rationing among microfinance borrowers: designed survey instruments, adapted the Direct Elicitation Method to distinguish quantity-, price-, and risk-rationed borrowers, and analyzed the resulting measures.

2020–2021 **Research Associate**

BRAC Institute of Governance and Development (PI: Dr. Narayan Das)

- Impact evaluation of skill development programme for disadvantaged youth.
- Chapter on youth migration for BRAC's Urban Development Program.

2019–2020 **Research Assistant**

BRAC James P. Grant School of Public Health (PI: Dr. Zahidul Quayyum)

- *Policy report* on Bangladesh's health system response to COVID-19.
- Social return on investment of BRAC's Health, Nutrition, and Population Program.

Bangladesh Institute of Development Studies (PI: Dr. Mainul Hoque)

- Price volatility index using large datasets of agricultural commodity prices.
- Empirical and GIS analysis for research on crop diversification trends in Bangladesh.

University of Dhaka (PI: Prof. Sayema Haque)

- Gender responsive budget report for the Ministry of Health and Family Welfare

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

2022–2023 **Teaching Assistant**, University of California, Davis

Econometrics for Business Decisions (ARE 107)

Econometric Theory & Applications (ARE 106)

Intermediate Microeconomics (ARE 100A)

Corporate Finance (ARE 172)

2024–2026 **Guest Lectures**, University of California, Davis

Introduction to Applied Research Methods (ARE 202A, PhD): Experimental protocols and findings from fieldwork in Bangladesh

Introduction to Applied Research Methods (ARE 202A, PhD): Designing and implementing lab-in-the-field experiments

Senior Research Thesis (ARE 194HB): Preparing and presenting conference posters

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Session Moderator, AAEA Annual Meeting, 2026; Reviewer, Pacific Conference for Development Economics, 2026

SKILLS & METHODS

Programming: Python (pandas, scikit-learn, statsmodels, data pipelines, string matching), R, Stata, Julia, SQL

Methods: Causal inference (DiD, IV, event study, synthetic control), experimental design, panel data econometrics, machine learning (regularization, tree-based and ensemble methods), NLP (topic modeling, sentiment analysis)

Tools & Platforms: VS Code, L^AT_EX, Git, ArcGIS, SurveyCTO

Additional Training: *Supervised Machine Learning; Advanced Learning Algorithms; Text Analysis and Natural Language Processing for Data Science*

Languages: English (fluent), Bangla (native), Spanish (conversational)